The Negro Speaks of Rivers

Langston Hughes · 1921

Source: Langston Hughes, "The Negro Speaks of Rivers" (1921). Public domain. Complete poem.

> Written when Hughes was seventeen, this landmark poem of the Harlem Renaissance links the depth of Black identity and history to the world's great rivers — from the Euphrates and Nile to the Mississippi.

I've known rivers:
I've known rivers ancient as the world and older than the flow of human blood in human veins.
My soul has grown deep like the rivers.
I bathed in the Euphrates when dawns were young.
I built my hut near the Congo and it lulled me to sleep.
I looked upon the Nile and raised the pyramids above it.
I heard the singing of the Mississippi when Abe Lincoln went down to New Orleans, and I've seen its muddy bosom turn all golden in the sunset.
I've known rivers:
Ancient, dusky rivers.
My soul has grown deep like the rivers.